

Whiting (*Merlangius merlangus*) in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k (southern Celtic Seas and western English Channel)

ICES advice on fishing opportunities

ICES advises that when the maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach and precautionary considerations are applied, there should be zero catch in 2026.

ICES notes the existence of a precautionary management plan, developed and adopted by one of the relevant management authorities for this stock.

Non-fisheries conservation considerations

Conservation aspects and associated management measures may exist at a national or regional level but were not reviewed by ICES.

Stock development over time

Fishing pressure on the stock is above F_{MSY} and F_{PA} , and spawning-stock size is below MSY $B_{trigger}$, B_{PA} , and B_{lim} .



Figure 1 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. Summary of the stock assessment. The assumed recruitment value for 2025 is shaded in a lighter colour.

Catch scenarios

Table 1 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. Values in the forecast and for the interim year.

Variable	Value	Notes
$F_{ages\ 2-5}$ (2025)	0.67	$F = F_{average(2022-2024)}$
Spawning-stock biomass (SSB; 2026)	11 182	Short-term forecast; in tonnes
$R_{age\ 0}$ (2025, 2026)	273 745	Median recruitment, resampled from the years 2015–2024; in thousands
Total catch (2025)	3528	Short-term forecast; in tonnes
Projected landings (2025)	3007	Short-term forecast assuming average 2022–2024 landings pattern; in tonnes
Projected discards (2025)	521	Short-term forecast assuming average 2022–2024 discard pattern; in tonnes

Table 2 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. Annual catch scenarios. Weights are in tonnes. No information on % total allowable catch (TAC) change can be shown because the TAC area differs from the stock area.

Basis	Total catch (2026)	Projected landings (2026)	Projected discards (2026)	F_{total} (2026)	$F_{\text{projected landings}}$ (2026)	$F_{\text{projected discards}}$ (2026)	Spawning-stock biomass (SSB; 2027)	% SSB change*	% TAC change**	Probability SSB < B_{lim} in 2027
ICES advice basis										
Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach: $F=0$	0	0	0	0	0	0	16046	43	–100	100
Other scenarios										
EU MAP ^{^^} : F_{MSY}	1975	1566	409	0.375	0.31	0.064	14680	31	–58	100
EU MAP ^{^^} : $F_{\text{MSY lower}}$	1686	1358	328	0.315	0.26	0.053	14844	33	–64	100
$F_{\text{MSY}} \times \text{SSB}_{2026} / \text{MSY } B_{\text{trigger}}$	489	392	97	0.083	0.069	0.0140	15867	42	–90	100
$F_{\text{MSY lower}} \times \text{SSB}_{2026} / \text{MSY } B_{\text{trigger}}$	412	330	82	0.069	0.058	0.0110	15896	42	–91	100
$F = F_{\text{MSY}} = F_{\text{PA}}$	1975	1566	409	0.375	0.31	0.064	14680	31	–58	100
$\text{SSB}_{2027} = B_{\text{lim}}^{\wedge}$										
$\text{SSB}_{2027} = B_{\text{PA}} = B_{\text{trigger}}^{\wedge}$										
$F = F_{2025}$	3275	2519	756	0.67	0.56	0.114	13529	21	–31	100
$\text{SSB}_{2027} = \text{SSB}_{2026}$	1910	1315	595	1.62	1.34	0.27	11182	0	–60	100

* SSB_{2027} relative to SSB_{2026} .

** Total catch in 2026 relative to 2025 TAC (4720 tonnes).

[^] The B_{lim} , B_{PA} , and $\text{MSY } B_{\text{trigger}}$ options were left blank because none of them can be achieved in 2027, even with zero catch in 2026.

^{^^} EU multiannual plan (MAP) for the Western Waters and adjacent waters (EU, 2019).

The advice for 2026 is for zero catch because no F scenario will bring the stock above B_{lim} in 2027 with at least a 50% probability. Incoming recruitment remains low so even with zero catch in 2026 the probability of remaining below B_{lim} in 2027 is 100%.

Basis of the advice

Table 3 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. The basis of the advice.

Advice basis	Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach
Management plan	ICES is aware of the multiannual management plan (MAP) which has been adopted by the EU for this stock (EU, 2019) and which ICES considers to be precautionary. There is no agreed shared management plan between the EU and the UK for this stock, and ICES provides advice according to ICES MSY approach. Catch scenarios consistent with the MAP F_{MSY} ranges are provided.

Quality of the assessment

UK catch and sample data were revised for 2021–2023, causing some rescaling in the assessment.

There is a tendency for the assessment to overestimate spawning-stock biomass (SSB) and recruitment and underestimate fishing mortality. However, this does not impact the advice, as the stock status is forecast to remain well below B_{lim} .

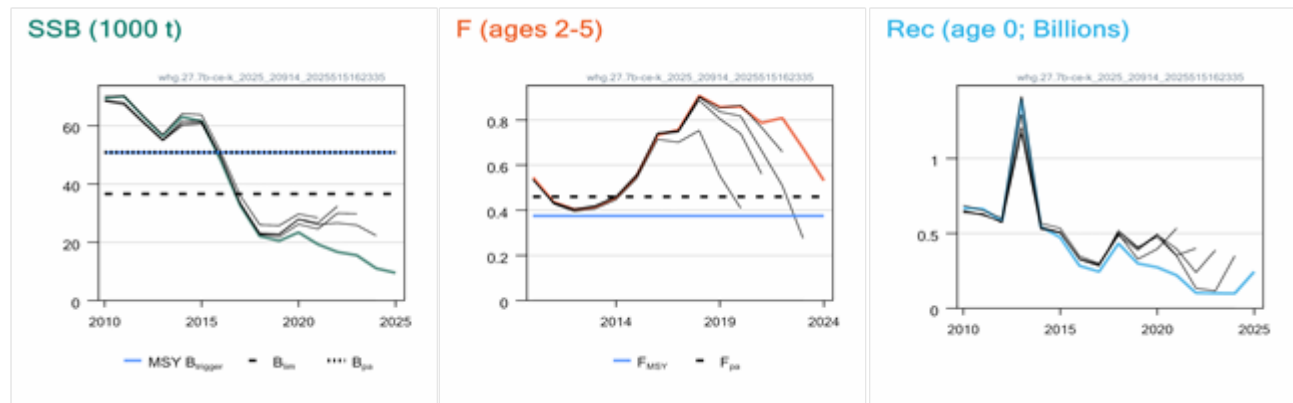


Figure 2 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. Historical assessment results (final-year spawning-stock biomass [SSB] estimate and recruitment assumptions included for each line).

Issues relevant for the advice

Estimates of discarding in 2024 are based on low sampling coverage of the main fleets catching whiting, and while considered appropriate for this year’s assessment, ongoing low sampling will be a cause for concern in future assessments. This may lead to uncertainty in the ratio of landings/discards split used in the forecast over time.

The assessment and the advice are for divisions 27.7.b–ce–k, including the rectangles 33E2 and 33E3, as whiting in these rectangles are considered to be part of the whiting 27.7b–ce–k stock (southern Celtic Seas and western English Channel). Landings data used in the whtng.27.7a assessment explicitly exclude those reported from rectangles 33E2 and 33E3 (Table 8). Data from these rectangles are incorporated into the advice for whiting 27.7b–ce–k. In 2024, whiting landings in 33E2 and 33E3 represented 42% of the landings from Division 7.a and constituted 0.8% of the landings from the whiting 27.7b–ce–k stock. The spatial limitation of the advice should be considered when setting total allowable catches (TACs) for the two management areas that span the whiting.27.7a and 27.7b–ce–k stock stocks.

Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k has historically been fished under a common TAC with whiting in Division 7.d. Mixing the biological and TAC areas for different whiting stocks will make it difficult to appropriately manage the exploitation rate of the separate stocks. For 2025, the EU and UK agreed to implement “of-which” clauses that, in effect, sets different limits for the two components (although this does not address the issue of the 33E2 and 33E3 landings mentioned above).

Mixed-fisheries considerations

Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k is caught as part of a mixed fishery (ICES, 2025a).

Reference points

Table 4 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. Reference points, values, and their technical basis.

Framework	Reference point	Value	Technical basis	Source
Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach	MSY $B_{trigger}$	50818	B_{PA} ; in tonnes	ICES (2021)
	F_{MSY}	0.375	From EqSim with segmented regression and fixed breakpoint (B_{lim}) capped to F_{P05} .	ICES (2021)
Precautionary approach	B_{lim}	36571	B_{loss} ; lowest observed spawning-stock biomass (SSB; 2008) from which stock recovery was observed; in tonnes	ICES (2021)
	B_{PA}	50818	B_{lim} combined with the assessment error; $B_{lim} \times \exp(1.645 \times \sigma)$; $\sigma = 0.20$ (default setting); in tonnes	ICES (2021)
	F_{PA}	0.375	F_{P05} ; the F that leads to $SSB \geq B_{lim}$ with 95% probability	ICES (2021)
Management plan*	MAP MSY $B_{trigger}$	50818	MSY $B_{trigger}$; in tonnes	EU (2019), ICES (2021)
	MAP B_{lim}	36571	B_{lim} ; in tonnes	EU (2019), ICES (2021)
	MAP F_{MSY}	0.375	F_{MSY} .	EU (2019), ICES (2021)
	MAP range F_{lower}	0.315	Consistent with ranges resulting in no more than 5% reduction in long-term yield compared with MSY	EU (2019), ICES (2021)
	MAP range F_{upper}	0.375	Consistent with ranges resulting in no more than 5% reduction in long-term yield compared with MSY capped to F_{P05}	EU (2019), ICES (2021)

* EU multiannual plan (MAP) for the Western Waters and adjacent waters (EU, 2019).

Basis of the assessment

Table 5 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. Basis of the assessment and advice.

ICES stock data category	1 (ICES, 2023)
Assessment type	Analytical age-based assessment (State-space fish stock assessment model; SAM; Nielsen and Berg, 2014) that uses catches in the model and the forecast (ICES, 2025b)
Input data	Commercial catches (age composition of landings and discards); vector autoregressive spatio-temporal (VAST) standardized survey index (combined IGFS-WIBTS-Q4 [G7212] and EVHOE-WIBTS-Q4 [G9527]); maturity data (surveys and observer data; constant for all years); age-dependent natural mortalities (Lorenzen, 1996). Catch weights were used for stock weights. The stock weights-at-age on January 1st are derived from the catch weights by the Rivard's method (Seaver, A. 2012).
Discards and bycatch	Included in the assessment for the full time-series. Full observer-based estimates from 2003, partial observer-based estimates from 1999 to 2002.
Indicators	None
Other information	This stock was benchmarked in 2020 (ICES, 2020) and interbenchmark in 2021 (ICES, 2021)
Working group	Working Group for the Celtic Seas Ecoregion (WGCSE)

History of the advice, catch, and management

Table 6 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. ICES advice, the agreed total allowable catch (TAC), ICES estimates of landings and discards. Weights are in tonnes.

Year	ICES advice	Catch corresponding to advice	Landings corresponding to advice	Agreed TAC in 7.b–k^	TAC for 7.b–c & e–k^^	ICES landings	ICES discards	ICES catch
1987	Status quo F; TAC	-	7100*	18500		13720		
1988	Precautionary TAC	-	7000*	18500		15822		
1989	Precautionary TAC	-	7900*	19300		24276		
1990	No increase in F; TAC	-	8400*	24000		24099		
1991	Precautionary TAC	-	8000*	24000		14402		
1992	If required, precautionary TAC	-	8000*	22000		14419		
1993	Within safe biological limits	-	6600*	22000		17904		

Year	ICES advice	Catch corresponding to advice	Landings corresponding to advice	Agreed TAC in 7.b–k [^]	TAC for 7.b–c & e–k ^{^^}	ICES landings	ICES discards	ICES catch
1994	Within safe biological limits	-	< 9400*	29000		21659		
1995	20% reduction in F	-	8200**	31000		23559		
1996	20% reduction in F	-	600**	28000		19539		
1997	At least 20% reduction in F	-	< 7300***	27000		21067		
1998	At least 20% reduction in F	-	< 8200***	27000		19710		
1999	No increase in F	-	12400***	25000		20180	5420	25600
2000	17% reduction in F	-	< 13100***	22200		15644	4400	20044
2001	No increase in F	-	13500***	21000		13196	9877	23073
2002	No increase in F	-	27700***	31700		13640	7336	20976
2003	No increase in F	-	20200***	27000		11788	10337	22125
2004	No increase in F	-	14000***	27000		10321	19522	29842
2005	No increase in F	-	10600***	21600		12575	13598	26173
2006	No increase in F	-	10800***	19940		9908	5098	15006
2007	No increase in F	-	-	19940		9424	8439	17863
2008	Reduction in F	-	-	19940		6080	3760	9841
2009	Same advice as last year	-	-	16949		6574	4281	10855
2010	Same advice as last year	-	-	14407		9570	5346	14916
2011	See scenarios	-	-	16658		10084	3750	13834
2012	No increase in catch and improved gear selection	-	-	19053		10834	5116	15950
2013	Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach	-	< 17500***	24500		12131	4026	16156
2014	MSY approach	-	< 15562***	19162		12983	4672	17655
2015	MSY approach	< 18501	< 14230	17742		13110	6528	19638
2016	MSY approach	≤ 19076	≤ 15395	22778		15201	8259	23460
2017	MSY approach	≤ 25125	≤ 19825	27500		12377	2791	15168
2018	MSY approach	≤ 19429	≤ 13759	22213		9007	2139	11146
2019	MSY approach	≤ 15841		19184		6588	970	7559
2020	Management plan	6481 (range 4157–6481)		10863		5931	1266	7197
2021	Management plan	5261 (range 4458–5261)		10259		6153	1224	7376
2022	MSY approach	≤ 4452		10696		5115	2462	7577
2023	MSY approach	≤ 1715		9650		4266	397	4663
2024	MSY approach	0		23709	4718	3233	442	3675
2025	MSY approach	0		32374	4720			
2026	MSY approach	0						

[^] A combined TAC for whiting covers Subarea 7 (except Division 7.a).

^{^^} TAC allocation for whiting in UK and EU waters of divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k given since 2024 (EU–Norway–UK, 2023).

* For the divisions 7.f and 7.g stock component.

** For the divisions 7.f–h stock component.

*** For the divisions 7.e–k stock component.

History of the catch and landings

Table 7 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. Catch distribution by fleet in 2024, as estimated by ICES.

Catch	Landings					Discards				
3 675 tonnes	Otter trawls	Seine nets	Beam trawls	Gill Nets	Other gears	Otter trawls	Seine nets	Beam trawls	Gill Nets	Other gears
	79%	15%	3%	1%	2%	58%	1%	34%	6%	1%
	3 233 tonnes					442 tonnes				

Table 8 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. History of official landings by country and ICES estimates of landings and discards. Weights are in tonnes.

Year	Official landings						ICES estimates			
	Belgium	France	Ireland	UK England and Wales	Other s	Total	Landings from rectangles 33E2 and 33E3**	Landings	Discards	Catch
1999	448	16418	6013	1354	27	24260		20180	5420	25600
2000	194	9184	5358	1279	15	16030		15644	4400	20044
2001	171	7317	5365	963	16	13832		13196	9877	23073
2002	149	7546	5718	860	22	14295		13640	7336	20976
2003	129	5989	4516	772	12	11418		11788	10337	22125
2004	180	4870	4350	594	125	10119		10321	19522	29843
2005	218	5886	5774	482	136	12496		12575	13598	26173
2006	128	4710	4570	413	129	9950		9908	5098	15006
2007	127	3574	4864	575	87	9227		9424	8439	17863
2008	121	3072	2406	618	37	6254		6080	3760	9840
2009	87	2814	2798	827	25	6551		6574	4281	10855
2010	102	3463	4330	792	92	8779		9570	5346	14916
2011	100	4312	4752	739	175	10078		10084	3750	13834
2012	170	3710	5841	763	142	10626	43	10834	5116	15950
2013	226	4006	6888	907	93	12120	33	12131	4026	16157
2014	222	4928	6874	1057	40	13121	50	12983	4672	17655
2015	152	5634	6437	825	100	13148	34	13110	6528	19638
2016	186	6294	7700	891	39	15110	40	15201	8259	23460
2017	102	5256	6323	603	34	12318	20	12377	2791	15168
2018	103	3666	4636	594	871	9870	18	9007	2139	11146
2019	73	3234	2344 ^c	486	136	6273 ^c	24	6588	970	7558
2020	82	2669	2475	335	140	5701	14	5931	1266	7197
2021	82	2666	2923 ^c	354	66	6091 ^c	59	6153	1224	7377
2022	75	2750	1943 ^c	308	14	5090 ^c	21	5115	2462	7577
2023*	69	2385	1419	329	32	4234	33	4266	397	4663
2024*	37	3532	666	337	38	4610	26	3233	442	3675

* Preliminary.

** Landings in the southern part of Division 7.a (rectangles 33E2 and 33E3) are included in the assessment and are considered to be part of the stock.

^c Incomplete/missing as a result of part of the data being unavailable under data confidentiality clauses.

Summary of the assessment

Table 9 Whiting in divisions 7.b–c and 7.e–k. Assessment summary. “High” and “low” refer to 95% confidence intervals. Weights are in tonnes and recruitment in thousands.

Year	Recruitment (age 0)			Spawning-stock biomass (SSB)			Landings	Discards	Fishing mortality (ages 2–5)		
	Low	Value	High	Low	Value	High			Low	Value	High
1999	1713309	2171838	2753082	48065	53771	60154	20180	5420	0.69	0.81	0.94
2000	1498407	1887165	2376786	47350	52925	59155	15644	4400	0.70	0.81	0.94
2001	1136998	1424351	1784327	57323	64285	72093	13196	9877	0.76	0.89	1.03
2002	1013794	1282295	1621907	66520	74369	83143	13640	7336	0.52	0.62	0.74
2003	760038	968603	1234403	64112	71382	79476	11788	10337	0.47	0.56	0.68
2004	634416	798992	1006261	57582	64917	73186	10321	19522	0.60	0.70	0.82
2005	569516	711952	890010	40738	45380	50551	12575	13598	0.66	0.77	0.89
2006	608443	755430	937928	36365	40371	44819	9908	5098	0.56	0.67	0.81
2007	759647	941435	1166725	32904	36995	41596	9424	8439	0.96	1.12	1.31
2008	905141	1121145	1388696	31609	35313	39450	6080	3760	0.59	0.70	0.83
2009	1196698	1491069	1857851	39316	43928	49082	6574	4281	0.53	0.64	0.77
2010	537771	667843	829376	61849	69459	78006	9570	5346	0.44	0.55	0.67
2011	536160	663519	821131	62466	70037	78526	10084	3750	0.35	0.44	0.55

Year	Recruitment (age 0)			Spawning-stock biomass (SSB)			Landings	Discards	Fishing mortality (ages 2–5)		
	Low	Value	High	Low	Value	High			Low	Value	High
2012	468179	581601	722500	56361	62958	70329	10834	5116	0.32	0.40	0.50
2013	1111154	1395708	1753132	50703	56398	62734	12131	4026	0.34	0.41	0.51
2014	436850	544283	678137	56647	62993	70050	12983	4672	0.38	0.46	0.55
2015	379436	472343	587997	55020	61580	68923	13110	6528	0.47	0.55	0.66
2016	227739	283554	353050	42889	47883	53458	15201	8259	0.63	0.73	0.86
2017	196284	244523	304618	29277	32555	36199	12377	2791	0.65	0.76	0.88
2018	346284	433059	541578	19891	22066	24479	9007	2139	0.78	0.91	1.05
2019	234814	299213	381273	18402	20490	22814	6588	970	0.74	0.86	1.00
2020	204254	273745	366878	20673	23387	26458	5931	1266	0.73	0.86	1.01
2021	158113	220136	306489	16642	19293	22367	6153	1224	0.64	0.79	0.96
2022	72627	103125	146430	13697	16678	20307	5115	2462	0.61	0.81	1.07
2023	63034	100337	159714	11977	15541	20167	4266	397	0.40	0.67	1.15
2024	46201	99321	213517	7789	11058	15700	3233	442	0.25	0.53	1.12
2025	99321*	273745*	472343*	6016	9496	14690					

* Median resampled recruitment (2015–2024) as estimated by a stochastic projection.

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[Download the stock assessment data and figures](#)

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